Project 2 - Rate Your Ride 🚘

Group 9

Mauricio Diaz Reyes
Nolan Downing
Augustus Guy
Grace Carmichael
Oscar Ballinas

Table of content

I. Description
II. First Thoughts
III. Secondary Research
IV. Primary Research
V. Brain Storming
VI. Problem Space
VII. Prototypes
VIII. Intermediate Prototypes
IX. Evaluations
X. Pitch Video
XI. Final Design

Description

Our project dives into how rating systems in ride apps like Uber and Lyft shapes user experience. Through primary research conducted on campus including interviews with both riders and drivers, and some secondary research on rating algorithmic bias and economy labor, we were able to spot a couple issues like unclear user feedback, biased in rating, lack of app transparency and minimal user engagement issues. We think that the current five star rating systems don't do a good job in capturing real world interactions, which leads to inflated rating scores and feedback that aren't reliable. To combat this issue we designed a contextual pop-up prompt based rating system that gathers feedback from users throughout their rides, demonstrating clarity and fairness that provides better insights for drivers and creates a much more accountable platform for all users.

First thoughts

At the outset of this project, our team focused on improving the compatibility between riders and drivers as a way to naturally increase rating outcomes for Uber. We chose to focus on Uber rather than Lyft or other ride-hailing services because it was the platform our team was most familiar with, and we also had access to individuals with firsthand experience as both riders and drivers. We hypothesized that more compatible pairings would lead to more positive experiences and, in turn, higher ratings. This approach aimed to address the issue of low ratings in general, and the resulting risk of driver termination. To support this, we considered implementing a profile feature where users could indicate preferences for factors such as talkativeness and cleanliness. This was also intended to reduce common social uncertainty during rides, such as whether conversation is expected or desired. However, we ultimately moved away from this direction. While the idea addressed important social dynamics, we determined that it did not engage directly enough with the structure of the rating system itself. Additionally, we recognized that riders are often matched with the nearest available driver, meaning there is not always meaningful flexibility in selecting more compatible pairings.

Our next concept focused on redesigning the rating interface by replacing the traditional five-star system with a slider. This idea was motivated by the observation that users often interpret a four-star rating as positive, even though drivers typically need to maintain a significantly higher average to continue driving for Uber. By introducing a slider, we aimed to disrupt these existing assumptions and encourage more intentional feedback. We decided against this approach due to the insight that the additional friction caused by needing to drag the slider manually could discourage users from rating altogether.

From this point, we established a key design priority: minimizing effort and mental energy in the rating interaction. This led us to develop a button-based system that allows users to provide feedback with a single tap. We proposed a set of five labeled buttons that read, “Horrible,” “Bad,” “Good,” “Great,” and “Excellent.” This concept became our primary direction and served as the foundation for further iteration and refinement.

Secondary Research

To get a better understanding of the issues that occur during the rating process on rider apps, we researched scholar articles that can further explain what the issues are. Down below are research articles or relevant information that give intel on what issues could be present on the rating system on rider apps.

Rating faqs | riders | uber help. (n.d.). https://help.uber.com/riders/article/rating-faqs?nodeId=0539e772-747c-49a7-8c26-f28c65e6f14d

Directly from the uber FAQ, by uber's standard, drivers have to arrive on time to the pickup destination, have to treat riders with courtesy and be safe on the road to meet a 5 star rating. Uber explains what a 5 star rating means and what a 1-star rating is but does not include descriptions of what the other 3 rating stars mean. 1-star meaning there was a serious problem on the trip and a 5-star being that there was no issues on the rider. A driver's rating reflects the last 500 completed trips. If a rating does not reflect the quality of a driver's service, it may be excluded.

Toeman, J. (2014, December 4). *Why uber/lyft's 5-star rating system needs an overhaul | by Jeremy Toeman | medium*. Why uber/lyft's 5-star rating system needs an overhaul. https://medium.com/@jtoeman/why-uber-lyfts-5-star-rating-system-needs-an-overhaul-530062dd550

This article talks about the issue of how the rating system is viewed. The rating system is set up by a 5 star metric. People will naturally think that 3 stars is okay, 4 stars is good and 5 stars is excellent. In uber/lyft's standards, anything below a 4.5 is considered bad. This can lead to the drivers losing access to the app. The star rating system does not reflect the public's understanding of what a star rating system is. Riders give an overall rating which puts many factors into consideration. This can make ratings inconsistent. Uber/lyft systems also do not give the option to explain why a score was given. They propose a fail/pass rating system. They also propose a nuanced system where you rate the rider in different categories.

Chan, N. K. (2019). The Rating Game: The Discipline of Uber's user-generated ratings. *Surveillance & Society*, *17*(1/2), 183–190. https://doi.org/10.24908/ss.v17i1/2.12911

This source talks about the drivers experience and the anxiety they have to meet unclear performance metrics. They describe this issue by calling it the rating game.

https://medium.com/@jtoeman/why-uber-lyfts-5-star-rating-system-needs-an-overhaul-530062dd550

This article talks about where the rating system struggles and how it could be improved. They talk about how in our eyes the rating system means one thing but to uber it means something else. The rating system ultimately turns into a pass/fail system and it states that if it is meant to be pass fail it should be shaped to do that.

Toeman, Jeremy. "Why Uber/Lyft's 5-Star Rating System Needs an Overhaul | by Jeremy Toeman | Medium." *Why Uber/Lyft's 5-Star Rating System Needs An Overhaul*, medium.com/@jtoeman/why-uber-lyfts-5-star-rating-system-needs-an-overhaul-530062dd550. Accessed 27 Apr. 2026.

https://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/doi/full/10.1002/poi3.153

The article talks about how apps like Uber use customer ratings to manage their workers, and how these rating systems make it easy for platforms to oversee huge numbers of workers, but they also open the door for bias, especially against people from legally protected groups. The issue is that companies aren't allowed to make hiring or firing decisions based on things like race or gender, but if they rely on customer ratings and those ratings are biased they can still end up with unfair outcomes without technically breaking the rules.

Rosenblat, Alex. *Discriminating Tastes: Uber's Customer Ratings as Vehicles for Workplace Discrimination*, June 2017, onlinelibrary.wiley.com/doi/full/10.1002/poi3.153.

https://cyberleninka.ru/article/n/development-of-a-rating-system-assessing-the-quality-of-the-service-provided-by-drivers-in-a-taxi-aggregator-company/viewer

Good article to start to look at. It talks about what a taxi company should hold as its values and talks about different models that it could use (it is a russian article)

- "it should influence the driver as a motivating factor: rewards and punishments;
- it should provide a scalar value, which is calculated on a comprehensible basis with substantive rationale
- it should feature functions of parameterization and configuration;
- it should provide a special starting period allowing drivers to adapt to the system;
- it should provide for comprehensible feedback to the platform in order to make further modifications;
- it should be sensitive to changes in the driver's behavior: if a driver changes his or her behavior pattern, the RS should detect such a change within a short period of time." (Shevgunov)

Citation: Shevgunov T.Ya., Vavilova Z.A., Kravchenko T.K., Levchenko L.L. (2022) Development of a rating system assessing the quality of the service provided by drivers in a taxi aggregator company. Business
Informatics, vol. 16, no. 4, pp. 68-81. DOI: 10.17323/2587-814X.2022.4.68.81

Primary Research

Interview 1 - Rider

We conducted this interview to better understand how riders interpret and use the rating system, particularly whether ratings accurately reflect their experiences. We wanted to answer the questions:

1. Do riders understand what star ratings mean?
2. What motivates them to rate (or not rate)?
3. What factors shape their perception of a “good” or “bad” ride?

We conducted the interview by beginning with demographic questions and gathering information about how the rider uses the current system. Then we moved into more open-ended questions about experiences and behaviors. This allowed us to get some contextual information while also providing space for the participant to share specific examples and elaborate on whatever stood out to them in relation to our questions.

The interview revealed that ratings are often not thoughtful or accurate. The participant admitted, “If the ride was just normal I still give five stars,” and described a five-star ride as simply one where “nothing bad happened.” This shows a disconnect between ratings and actual experiences. Overall, this interview showed us that riders don’t really understand what star ratings mean, they have very little motivation to rate, and a ride being considered “good” or “bad” is highly subjective and dependent on rider preferences.

Interview 2 – Rider

This interview aimed to further explore rider motivation and engagement with the rating system. We wanted to answer the questions:

1. Why do users default to five-star ratings?
2. Do riders see value in the rating process?
3. How do factors like incentives, convenience, and context influence rating behavior?

We structured the interview similarly to Interview 1, combining questions surrounding how often they ride and when they rate with more open ended questions. (how they feel about rating, what would motivate them, etc.) We also introduced hypothetical ideas, such as a rewards system, to see what kind of feedback we got.

The participant confirmed that ratings are largely automatic and not reflective of real experiences. The participant explicitly described rating as a low-value task: “For me, yes [it’s a waste of time].” However, they suggested that incentives could increase engagement, stating that a rewards system “would motivate me… to complete it honestly.”

We also learned that factors like cleanliness and comfort matter a lot, but they don't really exist in the current rating system. Additionally, ratings are interpreted in an overly simplified way: "If I see 5 stars then I expect a good driver," illustrating that the system lacks nuance.

Overall, this interview reinforced that the current system produces inflated, low-effort ratings and fails to capture specific aspects of the rider experience.

Interview 3 – Driver

We conducted this interview to understand how the rating system impacts drivers, particularly in terms of job security, income, and performance evaluation. We wanted to answer the questions:

1. How do drivers experience the rating system?
2. How sensitive is it to individual ratings?
3. How much do drivers depend on ratings for their livelihood?

This interview primarily focused on the driver's long-term experience. We asked about work patterns, earnings, app usability, and the role of ratings in their job. The goal was to capture both practical and emotional impacts of the system.

We learned that the system is very high-stakes and sensitive for drivers. Despite maintaining an excellent 4.99 rating, they said that, "even a single bad review can impact that rating." This shows how one outlier can disproportionately affect overall rating. We also learned that tips (about 15% of earnings) are tied to rider satisfaction, which further stresses the importance of feedback.

Overall, this interview showed that drivers have to worry a lot about their income and security under the current system. The system is very sensitive to low ratings so one bad ride can really mess up a driver's average. Drivers depend on their high ratings in order to keep their jobs so it is incredibly important that these ratings are as accurate and helpful as possible.

Interview 4 – Driver

This interview aimed to explore external factors that influence driver ratings beyond service quality. The big question we wanted to answer was: Does the rating system fairly evaluate drivers, or is it impacted by variables outside their control?

We focused this interview around experiences specific to a part-time driver. Questions covered usability, income, rider interactions, and perceptions of the rating system. We asked the participant to share both positive and negative anecdotes.

The interview revealed that ratings can be influenced by factors like vehicle type and condition, suggesting that drivers may be judged on things beyond their control. The participant also described a time when an intoxicated passenger left the car in poor condition, which the driver shouldn't have to be penalized for.

Overall, this interview highlighted that the rating system is, in fact, shaped by uncontrollable factors that can make evaluations less fair and less accurate.

Interview 5 – Rider

This interview focused on understanding how safety concerns influence rider behavior, particularly in relation to leaving honest feedback. We wanted to answer:

1. Do riders feel safe giving negative ratings?
2. What prevents them from reporting bad experiences?
3. And how does safety factor into their overall perception of the system?

We asked the participant about their behaviors and experiences. We paid particular attention to decision-making in uncomfortable situations.

This interview revealed that fear can cause someone to not rate accurately. The participant described a situation where a driver behaved inappropriately, yet they chose not to leave a negative rating due to safety concerns, noting discomfort with the driver knowing their location. This showed us that riders may not always feel safe giving negative ratings. Feeling unsafe can prevent them from reporting a bad experience and safety is a big concern to many riders.

Brain storming

We started forming our first prototype that would be an optional survey that would pop up in the app next to the overall rating of the driver. We wanted to tackle the miscommunication between uber and the raters so we decided to have 5 options: Horrible, Bad, Ok, Great, Excellent. These would replace any spot where there would be a star rating system but hold the same values. We also planned on having a reward system that would encourage the users to do the optional survey. These rewards that

Chart

To organize our ideas, we created a chart that categorizes problems and opportunities into Focus, Consideration, Mid Priority, and Low Priority. This chart helped us decide what features to prioritize in our prototype based on impact and relevance to our research.

Focus (These are the most critical issues directly supported by our research):

- Flawed Rating (5 stars)
- Unmotivated when rating
- Driver has to meet a high criteria(4.6)
- Not enough feedback (Simplify feedback system)

Consideration (These factors influence how ratings affect the broader platform):

- Accurate ratings from riders
- Discrimination
- Safety
- Uber ride pricing based on driver rating
- Rating considered quality, not expectations

Mid priority (Important, but not central to our main solution):

- Transparency
- Pricing
- Buffer period when rating processes

Low priority (Ideas that could improve experience but were not essential):

- Personalization(ect. Quiet rides)
- Fluctuating prices
- Language barriers

Extras

- Picking and choosing driver
- Better UI

Problem Space

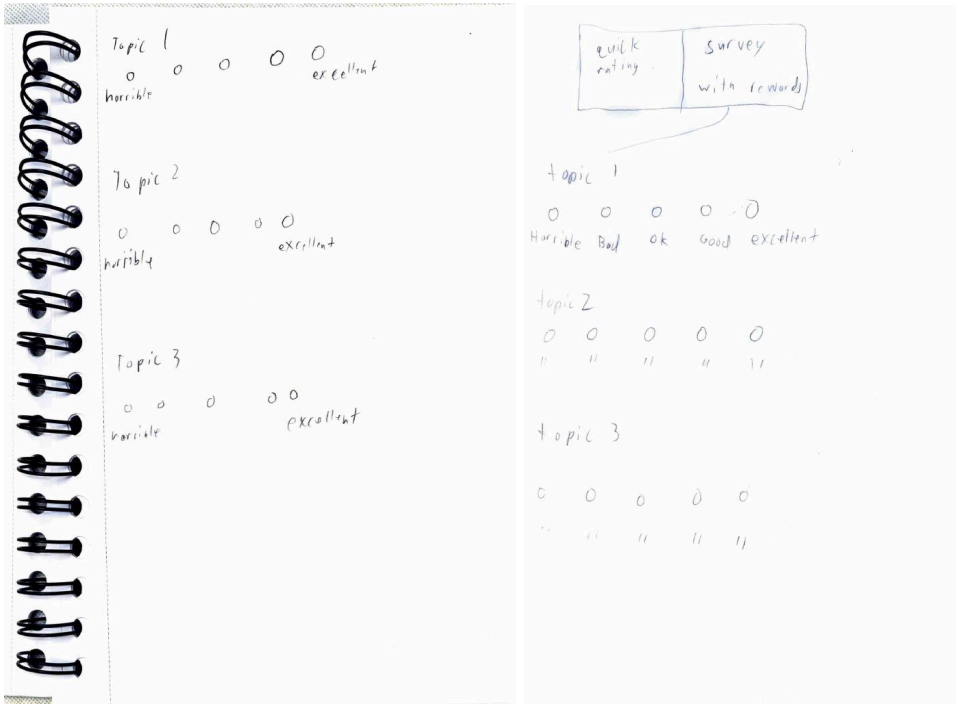
After conducting both primary and secondary research, we identified several connected issues within Uber's current rating system. One of the most critical problems is a lack of a shared understanding of what star ratings actually mean. Many riders assume that a four-star rating is pretty good, and may even reflect well on a driver. In reality, it signals to Uber that the driver should be deactivated, as this is the consequence of an average that falls below 4.6 within their

system. This disconnect means riders may give inaccurate ratings in the sense that they are communicating something that they may not agree with.

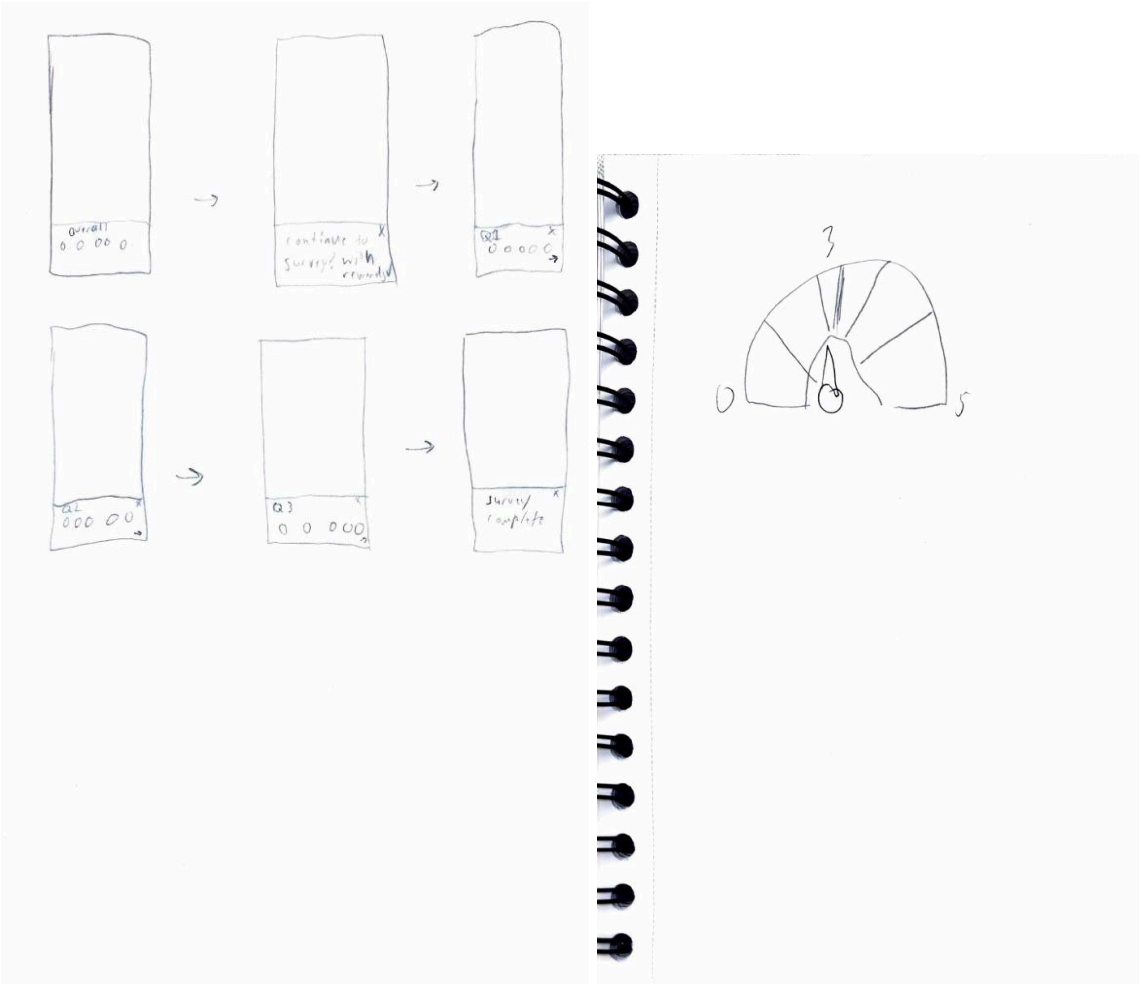
We also found that riders are generally unmotivated to leave ratings at all, and when they do, they tend to rate only at the extremes, 1 or 5 stars. This results in feedback that's simply not very valuable. It lacks nuance and accuracy since there's not actually a way to explain the rating or give a reason. This also leaves drivers without clear guidance on how to improve. Safety concerns can also contribute to this problem of inaccuracy in ratings. This is due to the fact that fear can cause riders to avoid leaving a low rating since the driver has information about them.

Together, these issues create a system that is both inaccurate and unresponsive to change. Ratings do not reliably reflect the quality of a ride, nor do they support driver growth over time. We chose to focus our design on improving clarity, increasing rider engagement in the rating process, and enabling more specific, constructive feedback.

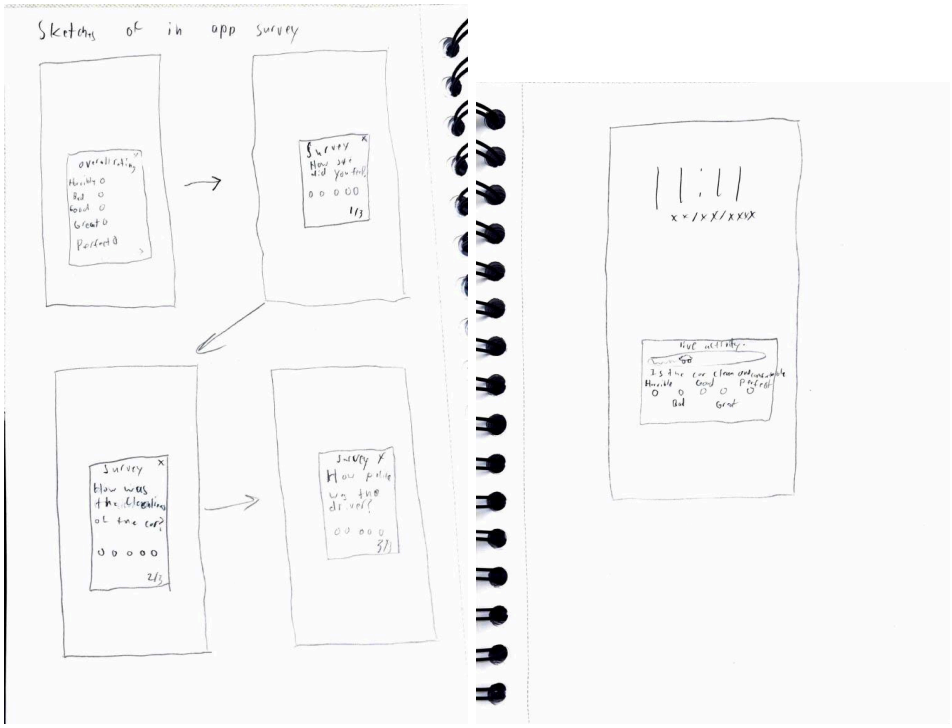
Prototyping



Here is our first iteration of our horrible, bad, good, great, excellent rating system. The context is that we wanted to have an optional survey at the end of the ride for someone to answer with the incentive of getting points towards a reward system.

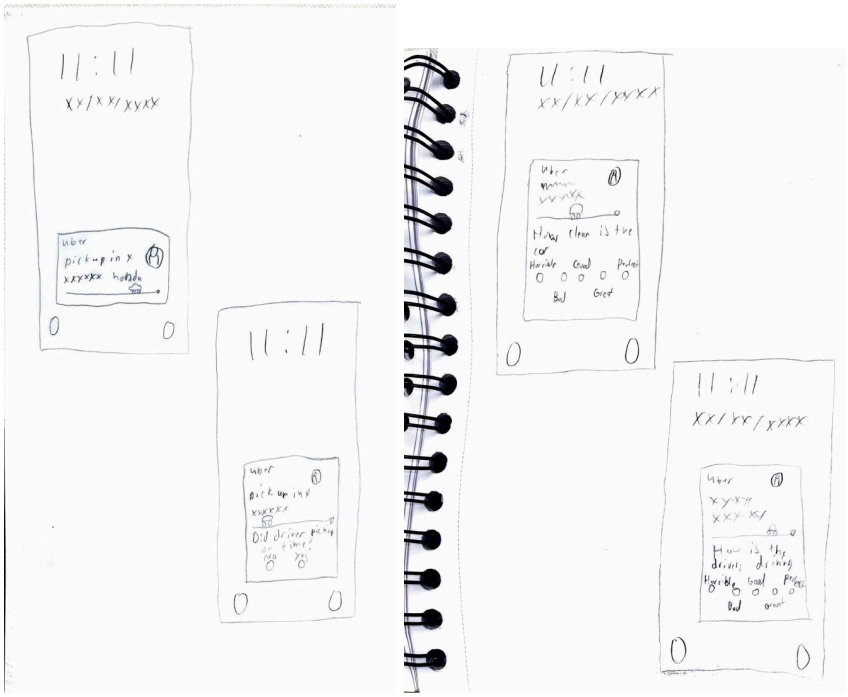


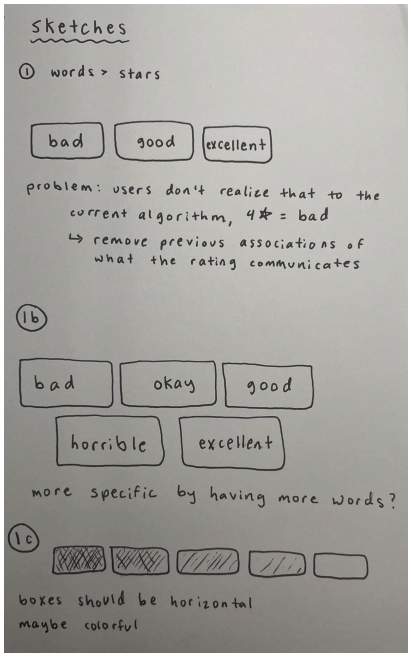
The sketch on the right is one of our early designs where we thought that we would have an in app survey after the overall rating with rewards.
The sketch on the right is a quick sketch of what the new visible rating may look like.

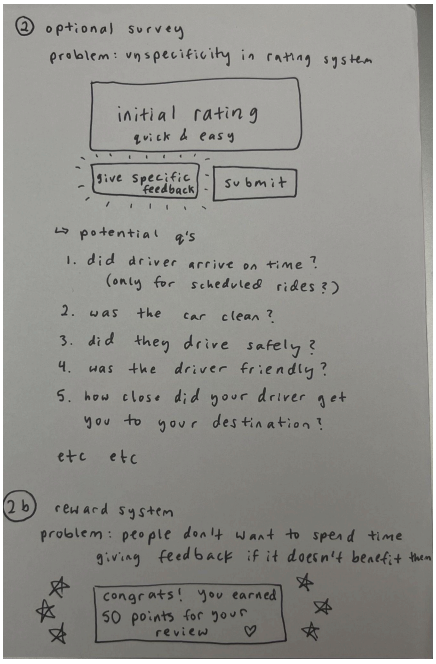


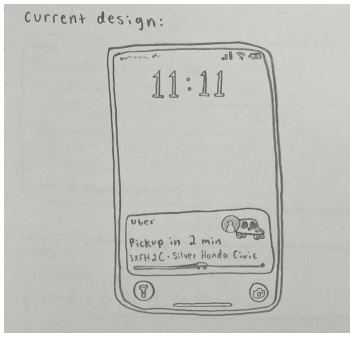
The sketch on the left is another iteration of the in app survey that contains rewards now having the words Horrible, Bad, Good, Great, Perfect.

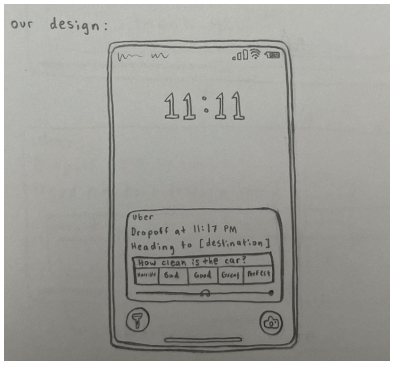
The rest of these sketches are pop up questions that would show up during your ride and you would be able to select Horrible, Bad, Good, Great, Perfect on your homescreen of your phone. Asking different questions throughout the ride.



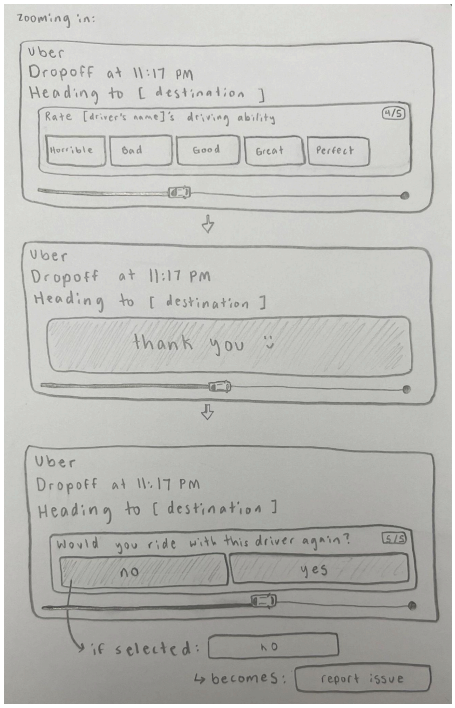




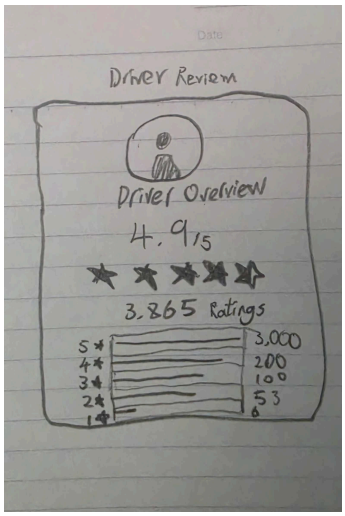


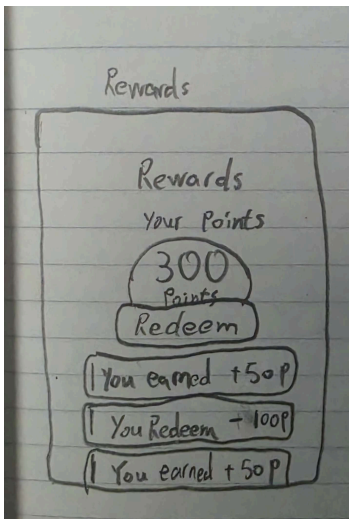


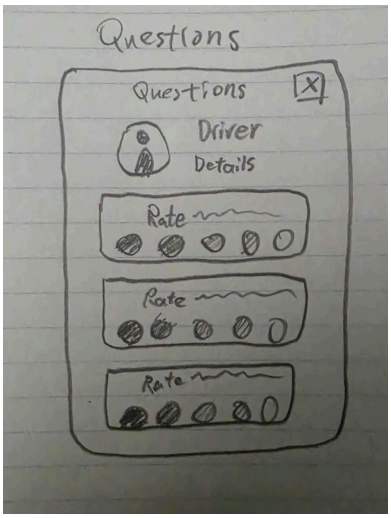
These are sketches talking about what our problem space is and possible questions we may ask. It showcases what Uber's notifications look like currently and what they will look like with our feedback implications. It also showcases our first iteration of our word choices of Horrible, Bad, Good, Great, Excellent. Which we soon switch excellent out for perfect. The sketches also show a possible look for what rewards could look like.

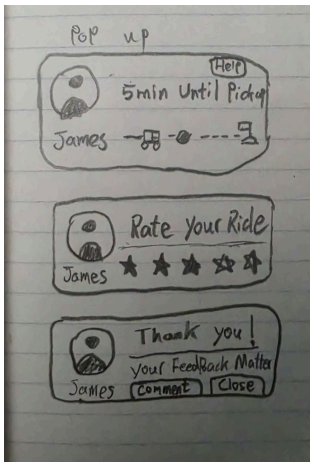


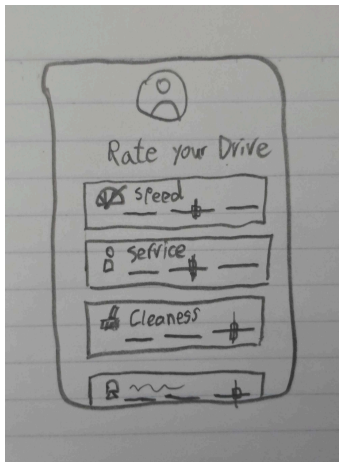
This sketch shows what the pop up banners look like and how they will look like after each other.

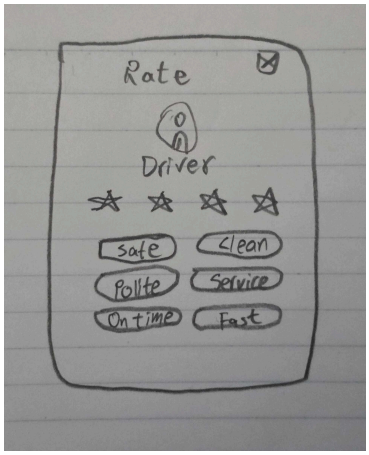

Date
Driver Review
Driver Overview
4.9/5
3,865 Ratings
5★ 3,000
4★ 200
3★ 100
2★ 53
1★ 6


Rewards
Rewards
Your Points
300
Points
Redeem
You earned +50P
You Redeem -100P
You earned +50P


Questions
Questions
X
Driver
Details
Rate
Rate
Rate

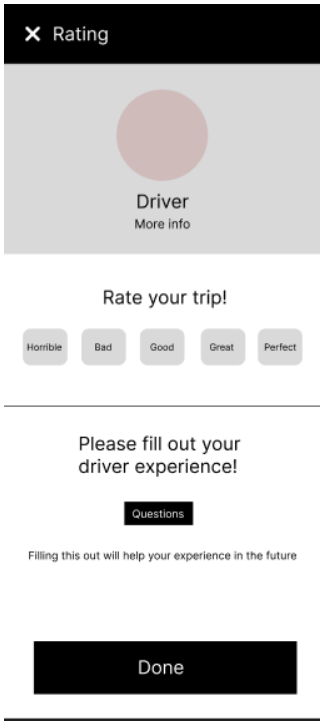

Pop up
Help
5min Until Pickup
James
Rate your Ride
James
Thank you!
Your Feedback Matter
James
Comment
Close


Rate your Drive
Speed
Service
Cleaness

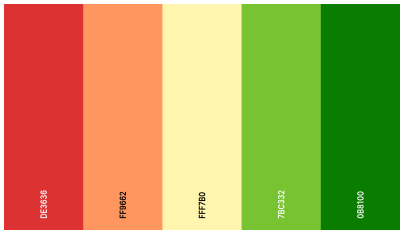

Rate
Driver
Safe
Clean
Polite
Service
On time
Fast

Intermediate Prototype

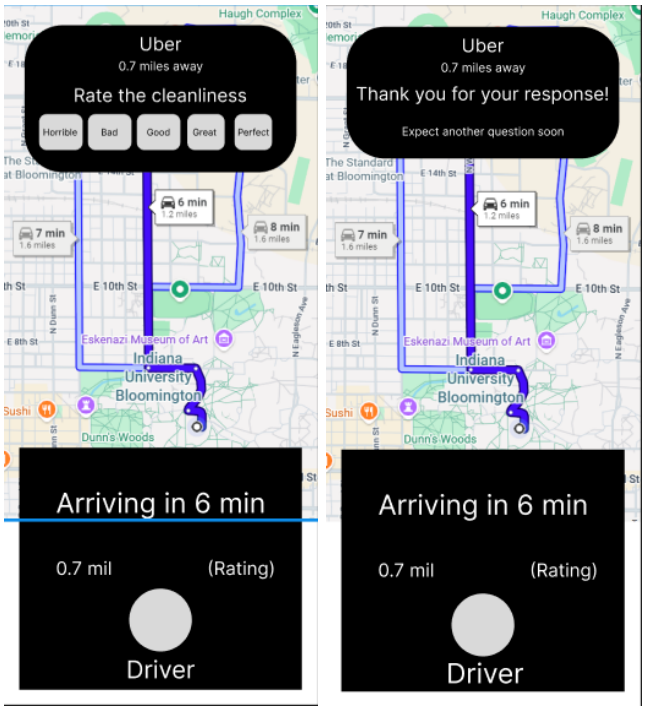
Rating system



From the sketches and design choices we made, we came up with this rough prototype that combines the UI that a user will see at the end of a ride and our version of the rating system which utilizes words instead of stars. What our system does is make a more straightforward approach to rating. A star system isn't understood by the average person and an example of that is considering a 4 star to be good when Uber does not think it is a good rating. Uber has the minimum requirement for a drivers rating to be 4.6 stars or higher. Any lower will lead to deactivation. For our horrible, bad, good, great, and perfect rating, a driver would only need to meet the criteria of meeting 3 out of the 5 words. That being good, great, and perfect. This gives a better opportunity for the driver to stay in good standing and gives a more accurate rating on their performance. By using words, we make it more straightforward for the user and give a better opportunity to rate according to their experience. Up to this point, some criticism we have received for this design is the usability for a certain type of disabled people and people/kids who might not know the meaning of the words. This flaw is an issue and to combat this, we wanted to introduce a color scheme which tackles this issue. For our future evaluations, we decided that it was best to evaluate the word system and the color scheme separately to ensure that both would have the same meaning even if not used together.



Inphone notification



This prototype displays our design for periodic notifications asking for your feedback during an Uber ride. When a user is riding with uber, to get the best possible feedback while not being intrusive outside the experience, users will be asked questions via notifications during the ride. The types of questions being asked will vary depending on what part of the ride you are in. Once the user enters a ride, initial questions will be asked. These types of questions will be questions that aim to get feedback from first impressions. During the middle of the ride, you will get a different set of questions that pertain to your experience so far. This will be questions like the drivers current safety and user satisfaction. Towards the end of the ride, another set of questions will be asked which aim to get feedback from the overall experience. The aim is to get feedback in the most efficient way possible. Most users don't touch the uber app after their ride which is why we proposed periodic questions throughout the ride. This will promote engagement and aim to help drivers to improve their overall performance. One criticism was how people might not feel motivated to answer these questions. To bring motivation, by letting the user know that their feedback provides a future opportunity for a better experience brings incentive to answer the questions. By letting the user know each time that their time answering the question is valuable towards their experience, we can bring in more responses. Drivers will see the feedback and have the opportunity to improve with each ride. As more time goes on with this system active, users

will begin to notice that there is a change in their experience which brings in more reasons to answer the questions.

Live notification



This is the live notification which will be present during the uber ride. Uber has something similar where they keep a live notification of a driver's ETA and how long it will take to get to the destination. By having the live notification, this will help create ease on the user and allow a seamless interaction without creating too much intrusion. Compared to the notifications you will get when on your phone, this allows the user to answer questions without having to engage too much to answer questions. The general layout will be the same compared to the in phone notifications. Although we have a large range of questions to ask the user, we understand that these periodic notifications can create frustration or irritation so the amount of questions will be fixed. 4 questions will always be asked for every ride. One at the beginning of the ride. One towards the middle of the ride and 2 towards the end of the ride. Having varying questions for each category can create issues with providing proper feedback to the driver. Having the amount of questions being sent to users depending on the length of the ride creates the issue of some questions being answered and others not being answered. This can create an imbalance and create confusion which is why we have 4 fixed questions that tackle the issues of cleanliness, driver attitude, the ride quality and the safety. This also brings in consistency and prevents a large amount of questions being sent to a user. The questions will always be available to answer in the optional questionnaire at the end of the ride if questions are not answered.

(List of questions)

Beginning of ride

- Rate the cleanliness of the transportation

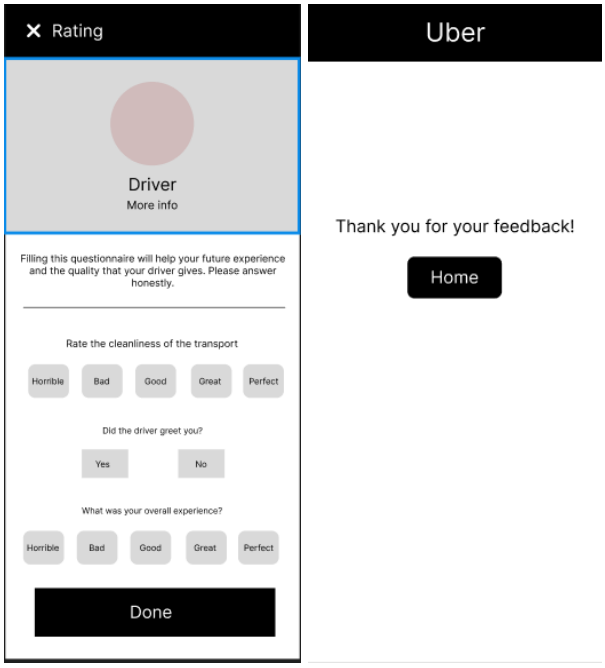
Midpoint of ride

- Rate the driver's interaction based on the appropriateness

Towards the end of the ride

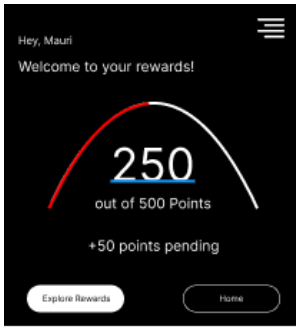
- Compared to other rides, this ride was (horrible, bad, good, great, excellent)
- Rate the overall safety of the driver

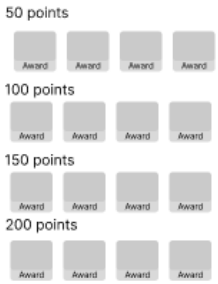
Optional Questionnaire



In the case that a user is not able to answer their questions throughout the ride, we give the option to answer the questions after the ride. The questions will be the same as the questions being asked during the ride. Our questions being asked are all optional so it is possible that a user might not answer any questions for their experience. Regardless, by providing the incentive that by answering the question leads to better experience, we can narrow the gap between those who answer the question and those who don't.

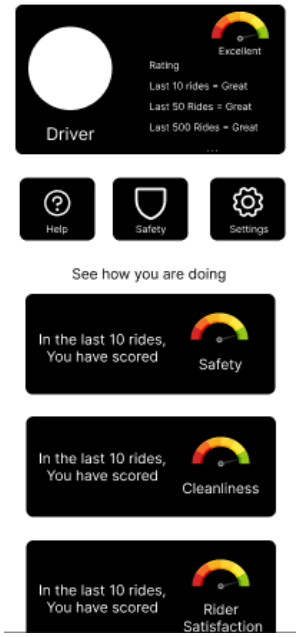
Rewards system





To combat the lack of motivation, we opted to include a rewards system for each question answered or for each questionnaire filled. This will promote more engagement and allow drivers to have a bigger pool of responses. Though having a rewards system seems productive upfront, we come across the issue of gamifying the system. During our group critiques, we were pointed out many issues that come with having a rewards system for this kind of application. Even though we will have more responses, we also sacrifice the accuracy of responses and risk causing more harm for drivers. Compared to other apps that have a rewards system, other apps require you to spend money to get points. In our design, you get points from filling out a form. The points stay stagnant for every ride meaning you can spend a lot of money for one ride or spend a very little amount for a ride and still receive the same amount of points. A quick fix would be to limit the amount of questions a user gets from each ride depending on the length of a ride but that invites more issues. Because of that, we ended up not including this design in the evaluations.

Algorithm



To better reflect a drivers score, an algorithm was thought up to weigh the 10 most recent rides towards the rating system. The algorithm would look at the last 100 rides and base its rating system on that data. The last 10 rides would be worth more points which aims to bring more accuracy. The logic behind this is that some part time drivers don't necessarily drive all the time for uber so having their rating be based on their last 500 rides which can vary with time can create inaccuracy. For full time drivers, having the rating system weight your last 10 rides can help bring your rating up. This can also better reflect a drivers rating with our rating system being mechanically different. This algorithm can help drivers but many issues come up with misleading ratings and how exactly it will work in practice. The more we implement this, the more complex it becomes to sort for our design. We decided to introduce this to our interviews but may not consider it for our final design.

Evaluations

For usability test 1 and 2 evaluation method was to give the tester a scenario and have them use our design as if they were using Uber. Below is the scenario used. They used paper prototypes and pressed on the paper and spoke out loud about their choices and thought process.

Usability Test Scenario

You are going from your house to a friends house 20 minutes away

The driver arrives on time at your house
The driver greets you and says hello when you get into the car
The driver doesn't talk and has some soft music in the background
You get a prompt on your phone asking if the driver arrived at the pick up on time
Driver is driving safely
The driver hits breaks a little hard to stop at a red light.
You get a prompt on your phone asking if the car is clean and comfortable
(imagine the car has no trash or stains and has a strong perfume smell)
You get a prompt on your phone asking how safe the driver's driving is.
You are close to your destination and you get a prompt on your phone asking if you would ride with this driver again.
You get to your destination in 22 minutes
You get a prompt on your phone asking for an overall rating of the driver.

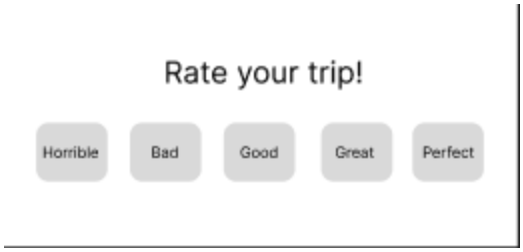
Usability Test #1 and #2

From usability test #1 and #2 we learned that the perfect may be too extreme and skew the answers closer to the middle than we anticipated. Also having the pop ups on the home screen of the phone seemed to really work and we even got feedback saying to not have it open the app. There wasn't a lot of confusion around how the prototype works. The ratings we got were mostly good and 1 great. The one great was an overall rating even though they rated everything else good. The other participant rated all of them good and chose to not answer "would you ride with this driver again?" This system worked mostly like how we expected, we wanted them to be closer to the middle but closer than we wanted.

Usability Test #3
Interview/Evaluation consent - Yes
User experience with uber - Casual use (when going out)

Introduction was given to the user where the project was presented to them and the purpose of the evaluation was given. The user prior to the evaluation has knowledge about what is going on and is ready to begin.

Notes-
Rating system



The first task for the interviewee was to look at the changes to the rating system. I explained that instead of the 5 star rating system, we changed it to a more straight forward rating system. I asked if the words associated with the rating were good enough. The words for the rating system are horrible,bad,good,great,perfect.

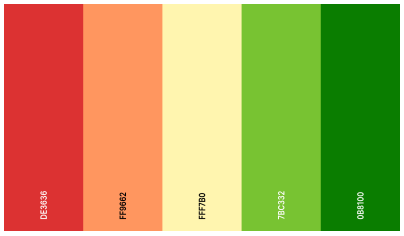
Feedback - User said perfect is too strong of a word and that word can be very subjective. The user suggested that perfect should be changed to excellent.

When the user was asked to interact with the rating system by clicking a bad score. They clicked horrible. When instructed to click a good score, they chose excellent.

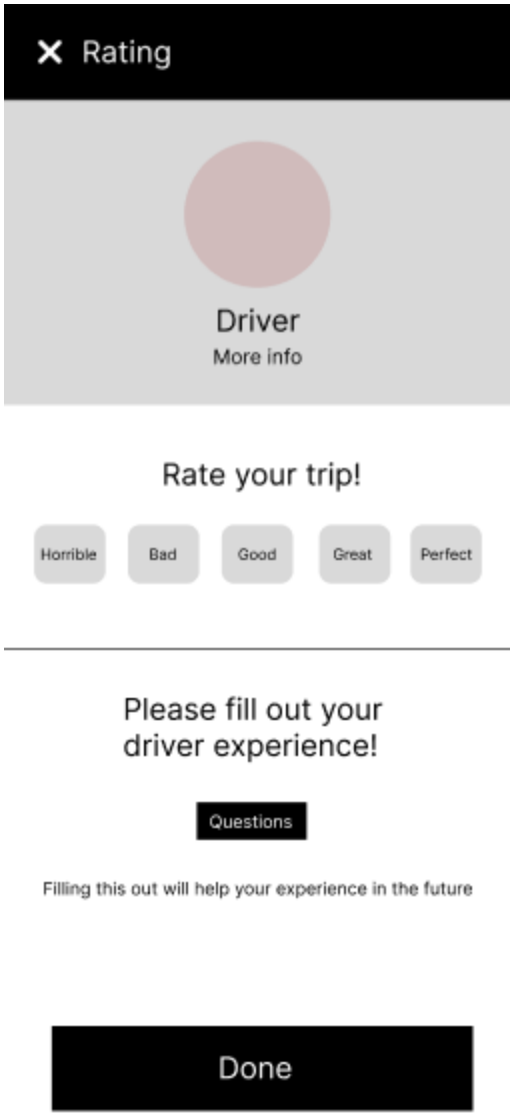
Feedback - One thing they suggested was to force users to leave a comment on why they chose horrible or bad. They said people become lazy and choose things without really thinking it through.

Color for the buttons were introduced via a separate doc. We wanted to know if the colors reflected the words.

Feedback- User said the color looks great and looks like they would fit in.

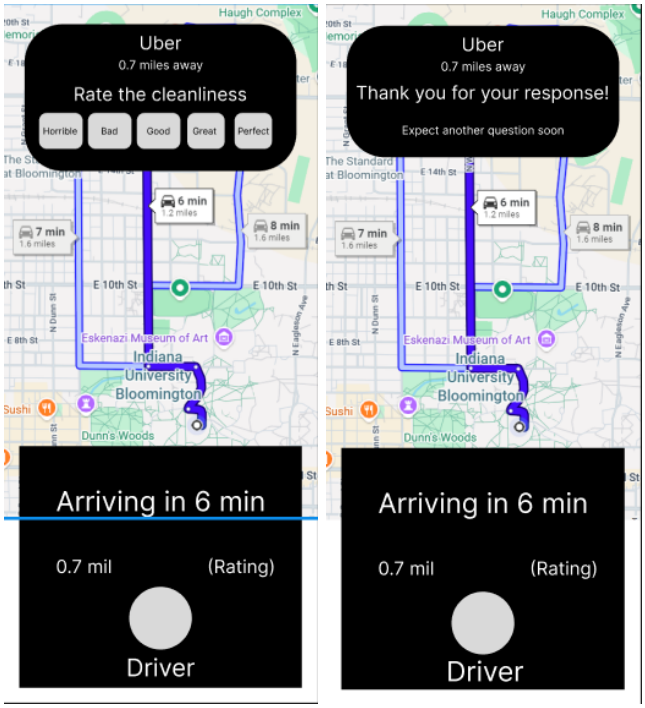


First page



The user was told to give an initial look at the entire first page which is the page you get once a ride ends. They said we should put in an option below the rating system to leave a comment since uber already has that option.

Notification while in phone



The user explained that during the ride, notifications are going to be given periodically. During the first ride, a simple question pertaining to initial thoughts. In the middle of the ride, you get a different section of questions where it asks about driver interactions. Towards the end of the ride, you then get the last section of questions where it asks you about safety.

Feedback- Users like this idea because when they are on uber, they are usually looking at the phone to see if they are going to the right place or if they are going to be on time. They also explain that they usually don't stay on the uber app after the ride so implementing the questions during the ride is smart.

The user then interacted with the UI and was instructed to answer a question. They were told that the car is clean and that it meets expectations. The user answered with great.

Feedback- User said that it's straightforward and that it is simplistic enough that it probably won't stress them out during the ride.

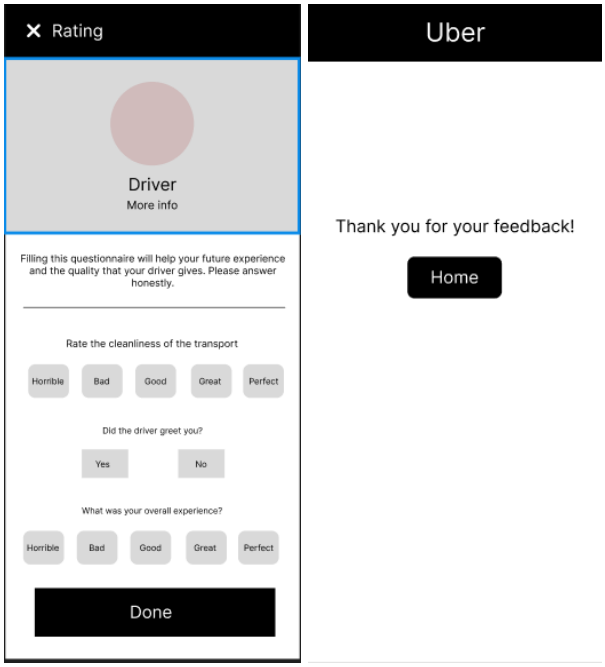
Lockscreen Liveview



The user was introduced to the live notification on the lockscreen. Here they will have the general live notification while they are on the ride. When a question is asked, it will change the notification and give you an option to answer the question. The user was instructed to answer the same question in a scenario where the car is clean and meets the standards. They then again answered with great.

Feedback- They didn't have much to add. They said that it makes it convenient if you don't want to log on to the phone. One thing they had an issue with is accidental touch to the screen which will answer the question without them intending. Other than that, they like the idea.

Questionnaire after ride



The user was explained that a questionnaire is available after the ride in case the user doesn't answer the question throughout the ride. The point is to secure some sort of feedback if possible. They were instructed to answer the questions and interact with the interface and see if they had any issues.
Feedback- The main issue the user had was with the question. They said we can improve on them more and add more questions. They said it looks pleasing and looks straightforward. The user had no issues navigating the UI.
Algorithm
The user was pitched the idea of an algorithm that puts more weight on the last 10 rides instead of averaging the last 500 rides. This would better reflect a driver's recent performance and will help their overall ratings.
Feedback- They liked the idea a lot and introduced that people do this part time and don't drive every week. So having the most recent rides weigh more than the total works in their favor. They said it was a smart approach and that a driver's recent performance should reflect their initial rating more.

Usability testing #4:

Rating Buttons

The participant was first shown the new rating interface, which included five options: horrible, bad, okay, great, and excellent. They were asked to describe what each option meant to them before interacting with it. The participant explained that the labels were easy to understand at a glance and felt more natural than using stars. They mentioned that okay felt neutral but slightly unclear in terms of whether it was positive or negative. They were then asked to select a rating based on two scenarios: a poor ride experience and a very positive ride experience. The participant selected bad for the negative scenario and excellent for the positive one.

Observation – The participant made selections quickly without hesitation, suggesting the system is intuitive.

Clarity and Meaning of Ratings

The participant was asked whether the labeled system better communicates how ratings impact drivers compared to the star system.

Feedback – They said the labeled system feels more honest and easier to interpret. They noted that with stars, they often assume 4 stars is a good rating, but the labeled system makes them think more about their choice.

Optional Feedback

After choosing a rating, the participant was shown the optional survey prompt. They were not told to complete it immediately, but instead asked what they would naturally do. The participant initially said they might skip it if they were busy. However, after being told the survey would be short, they said they would be more likely to complete it.

Observation – The willingness to engage depends heavily on perceived time and effort.

Survey Interaction

The participant then completed a sample version of the survey. The questions focused on general ride quality and driver behavior. They moved through the questions quickly and did not express confusion at any step.

Feedback – They appreciated that the survey was simple and did not require typing long responses. However, they suggested that too many questions could discourage users from finishing it.

Lockscreen Notifications

The participant was then introduced to the idea of answering questions directly from the lockscreen without opening the app. They were asked to interact with a notification in this format.

Feedback – The participant said this feature is convenient, especially if they don't want to fully open their phone. However, they expressed concern about accidentally tapping an answer without intending to.

First Notification (Beginning of Ride)

At the start of the test, the participant was told to imagine they had just entered the ride. A notification appeared asking for their initial impression of the experience. The participant was asked what they would do upon seeing the notification.

Feedback – The participant said they would likely notice it since they usually check their phone early in the ride. They mentioned that answering a quick question at this stage feels reasonable if it does not interrupt anything important.

Observation – Early-stage engagement seems natural because users are already paying attention to their phone.

Mid-Ride Notification

The second notification appeared during the middle of the ride and asked about the driver's behavior and overall interaction. The participant was instructed to respond to a scenario where

the driver was polite and the ride was comfortable. They selected a positive response without hesitation.

Feedback – The participant said the question was easy to answer and did not require much thought. They also mentioned that answering during the ride feels more accurate since the experience is still happening. However, they noted that too many notifications could become annoying if they appear too frequently.

Final Notification

Toward the end of the ride, the participant received a final notification focused on safety and overall satisfaction. They responded based on a positive scenario and completed the interaction quickly.

Feedback – The participant liked that the questions were spread out instead of all appearing at the end. They felt this reduced effort and made the process feel less overwhelming.

Cognitive Walkthrough

Primary user: College-aged rider (18–25), casual Uber user, uses app quickly, minimal engagement beyond ordering rides, often skips ratings or defaults to 5 stars. Values speed, low effort, and safety.

Features being evaluated:

- Lock screen/banner notifications during ride
- Quick-response buttons (Horrible → Excellent)
- Yes/No prompts (e.g., “Would you ride again?”)
- Post-ride optional questions

We want to know: if the user knows what to do, and if they do it, do they know they made progress?

Step 1: User receives first notification (pickup experience), notification appears - “Did your driver arrive on time? (Yes/No)”

1. Will user know what to do? Yes. This will read as simple and familiar.
2. Will user know they made progress? Yes, the button will turn green and provide a “thank you” message. This will subsequently be replaced with a second question.

Step 2: User answers via lock screen, taps “Yes” directly from notification

1. Will user know what to do? Yes, interaction is extremely low effort
2. Will user know they made progress? Yes

Issues: risk of accidental taps, no confirmation or undo option

Step 3: Mid-ride prompt (cleanliness), notification prompts, “How clean and comfortable is the car?” (Horrible → Excellent)

1. Will user know what to do? Yes, labeled buttons are intuitive
2. Will user know they made progress? Yes

Step 4: App prompts to rate driving safety after minor braking event

1. Will user know what to do? Yes, but requires judgment in context
2. Will user know they made progress? Yes

Issues: no guidance on what should count as good, great, excellent, etc.

Step 5: “Would you ride again?” prompt, Yes/No question near end of ride

1. Will user know what to do? Yes
2. Will user know they made progress? Yes

Issues: Binary may oversimplify nuanced experiences

Step 6: Post-ride optional questionnaire, allows user to complete missed questions

1. Will user know what to do? Yes
2. Will user know they made progress? Yes

Issues: Relies on user motivation after ride, which is low

Key Findings

1. Accidental interaction risk Lock screen responses are fast but error-prone. No confirmation could lead to incorrect data
2. Ambiguity in rating language. People might not be sure what the words actually mean to the system/outcome.
3. Motivation is still lacking

Takeaways & Ideas for moving forward

1. Prevent accidental input

Add a small “undo” button

2. Define rating scale

Add a small option to click for more information about what each word means. Ex. Good (met expectations), Great (above expectations), Excellent (above and beyond service)

3. Show impact of feedback (improve motivation)

Add small message that says, “This helps improve driver safety scores”, add a small progress bar

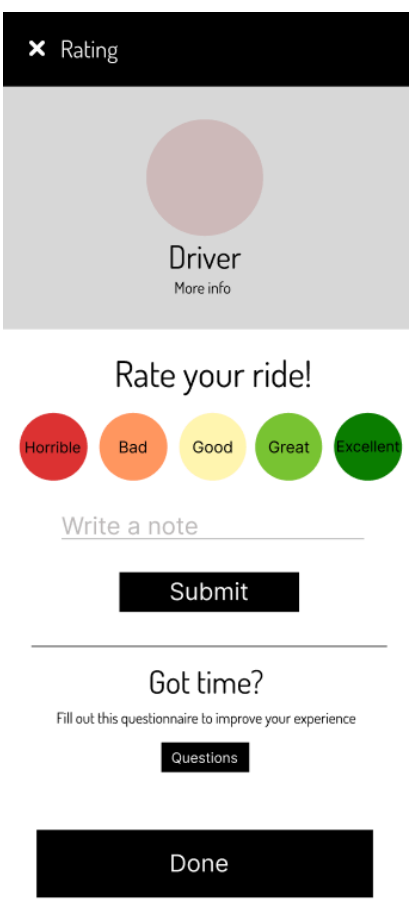
Across all of our evaluations we found that our design was intuitive and easier to understand compared to the traditional 5 star system. The labeled rating buttons seemed to be an improvement and helped them make more deliberate decisions. However, the word perfect was too strong of a word and skewed the answers towards the middle. We have now chosen to swap out perfect back to excellent as in our earlier designs. The notifications on the lock screen because riders would already be on or checking their phone during the ride and spreading the questions along the ride reduced fatigue. There were concerns about accidental taps on the screen. Some participants also added that they may be more engaged if negative feedback required more in depth explanations. Overall, the system worked as intended.

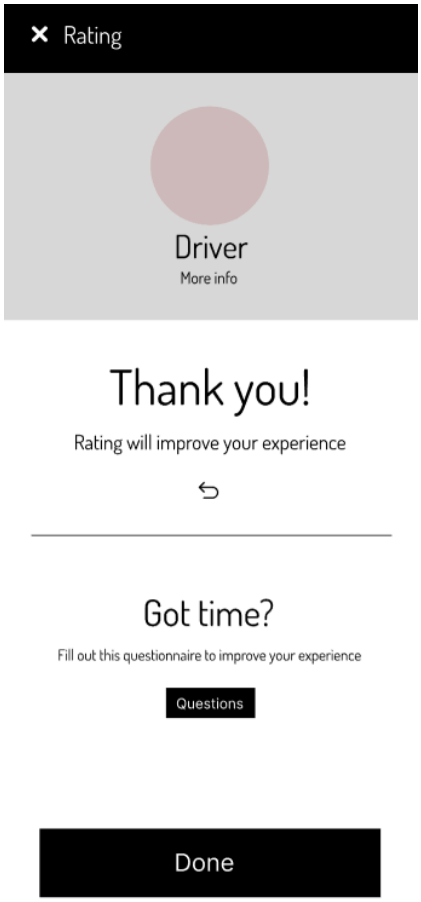
Pitch Video

Project 2 vid

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=KKlWQhUVLjY

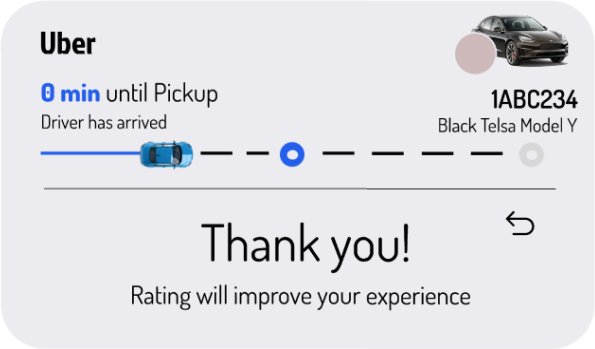
Final Design



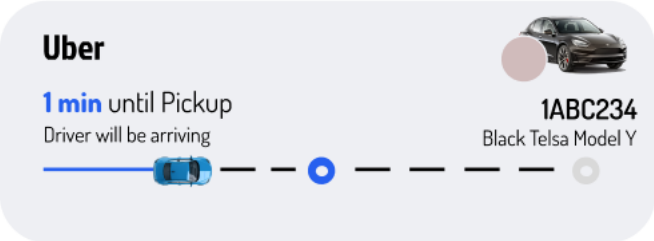


These are the pages that will appear after your ride is completed on the app. Once the ride is completed, it will let you rate your ride and you can select one of the color coordinated options from Horrible, Bad, Good, Great, Excellent. It gives you the chance to add any additional feedback and once done you can submit your rating/feedback. If some or none of the questions were answered throughout the ride, you can select the Questions button to go back and answer the questions. You can also go back and change your answers if you accidentally answered one or if you changed your mind.

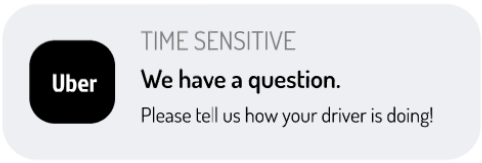


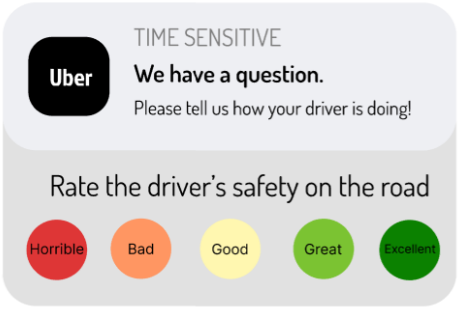


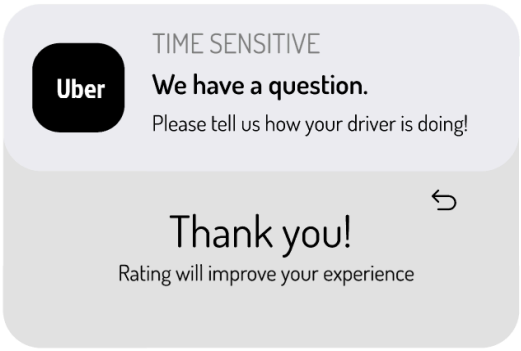
These are the notification pop ups that show on the lock screen of the phone. These are how the questions appear and you can answer the questions from the lock screen by selecting one of the color coordinated options from Horrible, Bad, Good, Great, Excellent. Once answered, it will thank you and it will also give you the chance to go back and edit your answer if you select the go back button.



This is the notification pop up that shows up before the driver shows up to pick you up. It lets you know what type of car the driver has with its driver plate number. It gives you a profile picture of the driver and the model of the car with a small image of it. It also lets you know how far the driver is to the destination.







These are the notification pop ups that show up while you're on your phone. It is very similar to the lock screen page. These are how the questions appear and you can answer the questions from the lock screen by selecting one of the color coordinated options from Horrible, Bad, Good, Great, Excellent. Once answered, it will thank you and it will also give you the chance to go back and edit your answer if you select the go back button.



Finally, we have the optional survey that is available to the user after the ride. This is only given if the user didn't answer any or some of the questions during the ride. This is more of an opportunity to gather as much feedback as possible. If a user answers all the questions during the ride, the survey will not appear. If the user missed one question or more during the ride, they will still be available to answer after the ride. This survey is not forced but the incentive is that giving feedback equals higher quality rides. On the initial rating screen, the option to fill out the survey will appear below the rating system. Users will be redirected to this page above and will be given the list of questions to answer. Once they are done giving ratings, they can press "done" at the bottom and finish the interaction.